

PAULT DOCUMENTATION

2026 02 26 Ux Collapsible Panels Design

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Theme: Clean Technical

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UX Redesign: Collapsible Panel System

Date: 2026-02-26

Status: Approved

Scope: Main window layout, block editor, animations

Problem Statement

The current 3-column NavigationSplitView (Sidebar | Detail | Inspector) causes UX friction:

- **Too crowded** — elements compete for attention
- **Poor hierarchy** — unclear what's primary vs secondary
- **Awkward navigation** — moving between columns feels clunky
- **Wasted space** — screen real estate not used efficiently

User goal: Focus on editing — prompt content should dominate; everything else should get out of the way.

Solution: Hybrid Collapsible Panel System

Slide-out panels that auto-collapse when editing begins. Combines manual control with intelligent auto-hide behavior.

Core Layout Architecture

Replace `NavigationSplitView` with single-column editor and collapsible side panels:

[illegible]

Key behaviors:

- Default: Editor only (panels collapsed)
- Toggle shortcuts: Cmd+1 for sidebar, Cmd+I for inspector

- Auto-collapse: Panels slide away 2-3s after user starts typing
- Hover reveal: Cursor at edge shows panel peek indicator
- Animations: Spring-based slide (200-300ms)

Sidebar Redesign

Collapsed state:

- Hidden entirely
- Toolbar shows [≡] hamburger icon
- Keyboard: Cmd+1 to toggle

Expanded state:

- Width: 220-260px
- Compact prompt list (smaller rows, more prompts visible)
- Sticky search field at top
- Horizontal filter chips (All | Recent | Archived | Tags)
- Floating "+" button at bottom

Auto-collapse triggers:

- User starts typing in editor → collapse after 2s
- User presses Escape → collapse immediately
- User clicks prompt → stays open (browsing mode)

Inspector Redesign

Collapsed state:

- Hidden entirely
- Toolbar shows [i] info icon
- Keyboard: Cmd+I to toggle

Expanded state:

- Width: 200-240px
- Single scrollable view (no tabs):
- Top: Title, Tags (editable), Favorite toggle
- Middle: Quick stats (created, modified, used count)
- Bottom: Version history (collapsible section)
- Stats tab only for Pro users

Auto-collapse triggers:

- Same as sidebar
- Exception: stays open while editing tags

Editor Area Enhancements

Minimal toolbar:

- Left: [≡] sidebar toggle + breadcrumb
- Center: Mode toggle (Text | Blocks)
- Right: [Copy] [Run] [i] inspector toggle

Full-width editor:

- Content-width constraint (~700px) centered for readability
- Or full width with user preference toggle

Fixed bottom toolbar (text mode):

- Variable summary
- A/B variant picker
- AI Assist button
- More stable than current floating toolbar

Keyboard focus:

- Cmd+Enter to run prompt
- Escape to collapse all panels
- Tab through variables

Block Editor Consistency

Apply same collapsible philosophy:

```
Default:
█
█ [≡ Library] Block Canvas Title [Preview] █
█
█ BLOCK CANVAS █
█ (full width, focused) █
█
```

Library (left): Cmd+[to toggle, auto-collapses after drag-drop

Preview (right): Cmd+] to toggle, shows Raw/Filled/Diff modes

Canvas: Full width when panels collapsed, keyboard nav works regardless

Animations & Transitions

Panel animations:

- Slide in/out (200ms spring)
- Content pushes (no overlay)

Auto-collapse sequence:

- Panel dims (0.5s) as warning
- Then slides out
- Moving cursor to panel cancels collapse

Focus transitions:

- Editor content fades (100ms) on prompt switch
- Cursor moves to editor start

State persistence:

- Remember panel states per session
- User preference: "Always collapsed" vs "Remember last state"

Keyboard Shortcuts Summary

| Shortcut | Action |

|-----|-----|

| Cmd+1 | Toggle sidebar |

| Cmd+I | Toggle inspector |

| Cmd+[| Toggle block library |

| Cmd+] | Toggle block preview |

| Cmd+Enter | Run prompt |

| Escape | Collapse all panels, focus editor |

| Tab | Next variable (in editor) |

Files to Modify

Main window:

- ContentView.swift — Replace NavigationSplitView with collapsible architecture
- SidebarView.swift — Compact layout, horizontal filters
- InspectorView.swift — Single-scroll layout, remove tabs
- PromptDetailView.swift — Full-width editor, bottom toolbar

Block editor:

- BlockEditorView.swift — Replace HSplitView with collapsible panels
- BlockLibraryView.swift — Slide-out behavior
- CompiledPreviewView.swift — Slide-out behavior

New components:

- CollapsiblePanelContainer.swift — Reusable panel container
- PanelToggleButton.swift — Consistent toggle buttons
- AutoCollapseManager.swift — Centralized auto-collapse logic

Supporting:

- Constants.swift — Panel widths, animation timings
- Preferences — Panel state persistence

Success Criteria

1. Editor takes full width by default (no visible panels)
2. Panels slide in/out smoothly with spring animation
3. Auto-collapse works reliably (typing triggers collapse)
4. Keyboard shortcuts work consistently (Cmd+1, Cmd+I, etc.)
5. Block editor follows same pattern
6. Panel states persist across sessions
7. No loss of existing functionality